↖ Topic Index

Emacs support for AppleScript

Description	Keystroke	Function	Note
AppleScript Support Last updated on:	PEL provides basic support for macOS AppleScript. • PEL enables AppleScript editing and execution support when the **pel-use-applescript** user option is set to **t**. • PEL provides help for editing AppleScript files via the **apples-mode external package**. • On macOS systems, PEL also provide a key hydra you can use to narrate any text in buffer out-loud using macOS synthesized voices and commands to execute AppleScript commands and programs. These would normally only be supported by Emacs running in Graphics mode, but PEL provides a simple functions to use them inside Emacs running in Terminal (TTY) mode as well. • When editing an AppleScript file (a file with the .applescript or .scpt extension) the buffer is automatically placed in apples-mode and the **<f12>** key is used as the mode-specific prefix . The **<f11> SPC** is the global mode prefix for the AppleScript commands. 2026-10-09		
Open this PDF file. See also: **Help/Info**	• **<f11> SPC a <f1>** • **<f12> <f1>**	(**pel-help-pdf** &optional OPEN-WEB-PAGE)	Open the **- AppleScript** local PDF. With **C-u** , **M--**, **M- -1** or **C- -1** prefix: open the remote GitHub hosted PDF instead. If the **pel-flip-help-pdf-arg** user-option is set it's the other way around.
Customize PEL AppleScript support. See also: **Customize**	• **<f11> SPC a <f2>** • **<f12> <f2>**	(**pel-customize-pel** &optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Open the PEL customize group(s) for the current context: applescript. Use this to open to change PEL user option variables the activate and control the various Apple script features such as the name of the narrator voice. • When a prefix argument (like **C-u**) opens the buffer inside another window.
Customize Emacs built-in AppleScript support See also: **Customize**	• **<f11> SPC a <f3>** • **<f12> <f3>**	(**pel-customize-library** &optional OTHER-WINDOW)	Customize Emacs **apples** group. • When a prefix argument (like **C-u**) opens the buffer inside another window. • Group belonging to files that have not yet been loaded are normally not accessible in Emacs and via the customize-group command. PEL, however, attempts to locate the file that defines a non-loaded customization group and will prompt you for loading the file if it finds it.
Open an AppleScript scratchpad buffer	• **<f11> SPC a s** • **<f12> s**	(**apples-open-scratch**)	Open scratch buffer for AppleScript editing. It is rendered properly and allows you to write AppleScript code without committing it to a file.
Static analyze or Compile an AppleScript file	• **<f11> SPC a c** • **<f12> c**	(**pel-applescript-compile** &optional ARG)	Compile the .applescript file in buffer. • With no argument: perform static analysis. • With **C-u** prefix argument, compile to a .scpt script file. • With **C-u C-u** prefix argument:, compile to a .app application file.
Text narration	On macOS systems only, PEL provides a set of commands to narrate text taken from a prompt or, • directly from the current buffer at point: a word, sentence, paragraph or region. • With PEL user option **pel-use-hydra** set to **t**, PEL activates the **hydra external package** and also creates a Hydra set of keys to help speed up narration. These keys are identified in the table below. • To start this Hydra, hit the **<f7> S** keys, then hit one of the following keys once or several times. • The keys that are in the PEL window hydra are all identified below with a **<f7>S** prefix, but when **pel-use-hydra** is set to **t**, after typing **<f7> S** once, you can hit several other window hydra keys without typing the prefix again. • While the PEL narrate hydra is active, you can also type other commands; the hydra will stay active. You can, for example, select a region and then type **R** to read it aloud. • To cancel the Hydra hit the **<f7>** key again. • A snapshot of the narrate hydra menu that shows up in the mini buffer area as soon as one of its keys is pressed is shown below. ⚠ If the **pel-use-hydra** is nil, then you must type the prefix before every narration command. Using the narration hydra is easier and more flexible. • The narration commands available are shown below. • The narrate hydra includes some navigation commands to help move around while being in narration mode. These are only showing inside the narrate hydra help menu. • The name of the PEL window hydra commands are not listed below. They all have a name that begins with **pel-∑say/** and ends with the same name as the command function listed in the Function column. For example, **pel-∑say/pel-say** is bound to **<f7> S t**. When processing text, PEL filters out the comments strings for the buffer's major mode. It also performs a set of text translation to help the narration. These are currently not configurable.		
PEL Narration Hydra Head: **<f7>S**	Read: **w** word, **s** sentence, **p** paragraph, **R** region Repeat: **r** last word Type: **t** at prompt Move to: **b** previous word, **n** next word, **B** previous sentence, **N** next sentence End: **<f7>** cancel		
Narrate the text entered at prompt	**<f7> S t**	(**pel-say** TEXT &optional FILTER-CHARS-REGEXP)	Say TEXT out-loud. Prompts for the text. • Use the Apple osascript to narrate the text using synthesized voice. • Quotes are not allowed inside the text. • The optional FILTER-CHARS-REGEXP can be used to exclude text from the narration.
Read the word at point out-loud	**<f7> S w**	(**pel-say-word**)	Say word at point out-loud and move to next word.
Read the sentence at point out-loud	**<f7> S s**	(**pel-say-sentence**)	Say sentence at point out-loud and move to next sentence.
Read the paragraph at point out-loud	**<f7> S p**	(**pel-say-paragraph**)	Say paragraph at point out-loud and move to next paragraph.
Read the selected region of text out-loud	**<f7> S R**	(**pel-say-region** START END)	Say text between region's START end END out-loud.

Emacs & AppleScript — References

Document	Notes
The AppleScript language	
• **AppleScript @ Wikipedia**	A good introduction and overview
• **AppleScript Language Guide**	Apple manuals
• **Introduction to AppleScript Language**	
• **AppleScript Fundamentals**	
BOOKS	
• **AppleScript in a Nutshell @ O'Reilly - Bruce W. Perry, 2001**	
• **AppleScript: The Missing Manual @ O'Reilly - Adam Goldstein, 2005**	
• **Apple Automator with AppleScript Bible @ O'Reilly - Thomas Myer, 2009**	
TOOLS	
• **Script Debugger 8, Late Night Software**	Popular tool for 30 years. Freeware since 2025.
LIBRARIES	
• **unforswearing/applescript @ GitHub**	Applescript applets, snippets, resources, and links